

The Indie Startup Reality Check

1,000 startups showed us their revenue on TrustMRR. Most aren't making money.

i Dataset: **1,000 self-reported startups** | 30-day revenue snapshot

MEDIAN MONTHLY REVENUE

\$282

50% of all bootstrapped startups make less than \$282/mo.

MEAN MONTHLY REVENUE

\$13,471

Massively skewed by a top 0.5% outlier tier.

The Power Law of Indie Revenue

Extreme right-skew: Mean revenue (\$13,471) is ~48x higher than Median (\$282).

Log-Scale Revenue Distribution

N=1,000



Top Revenue Outliers

- 1. Stan**
Creator Storefront
\$3,570,000 / mo
- 2. Stealth Company**
B2B Enterprise
\$747,000 / mo
- 3. GojiberryAI**
AI Intelligence (+23.6% MoM)
\$495,000 / mo
- 4. Rezi**
AI Resume Builder
\$260,000 / mo

The top 0.5% pull in \$200K-\$3.5M MRR, heavily distorting simple averages.

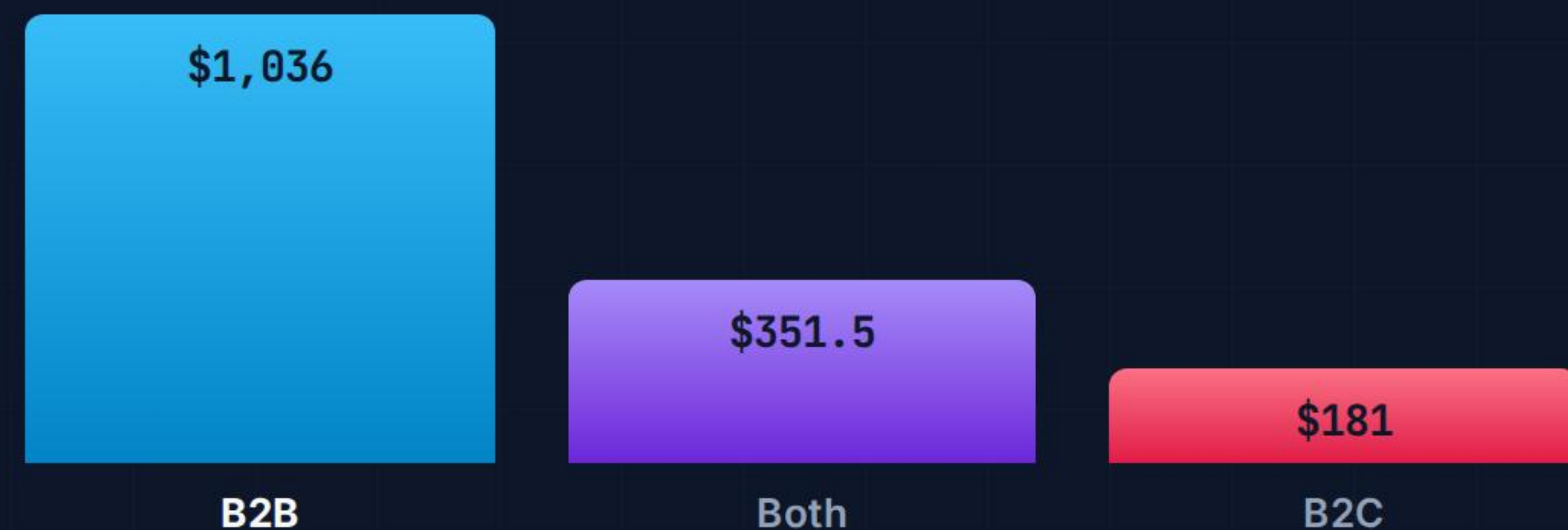
Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

B2B Beats B2C, Decisively

Business models dictate economics: B2B yields 5.7x higher median MRR and ~3.5x higher traffic monetization.

MEDIAN MRR COMPARISON

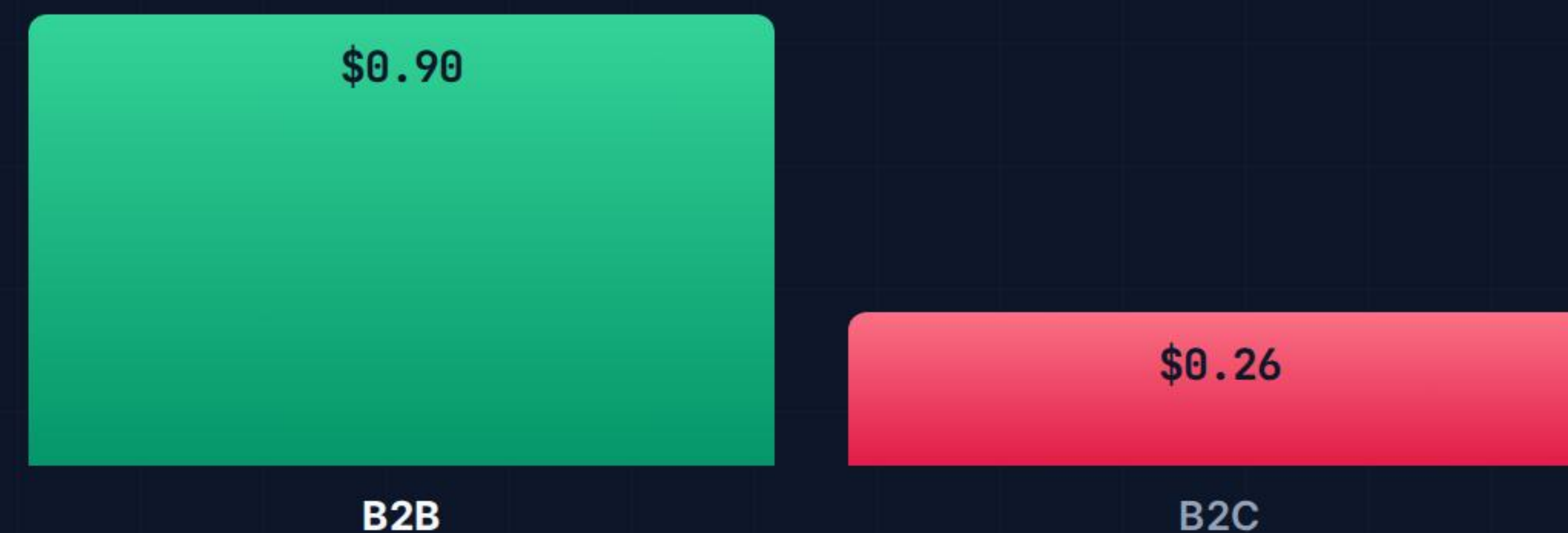
Monthly Recurring Revenue



5.7x MRR Multiplier: B2B startups convert customer willingness to pay into sustainable monthly retainers.

MONETIZATION EFFICIENCY

Revenue Per Web Visitor



3.5x Traffic Value: B2B founders extract \$0.90 per site visitor versus \$0.26 for B2C consumer products.

B2C requires massive consumer scale; B2B survives on high contract values.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

12

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Category Leaderboard vs The AI Paradox

Contrast: The most crowded category (AI) ranks among the least lucrative in median revenue.

CATEGORY RANK	CATEGORY NAME	SAMPLE SIZE (N)	MEDIAN MRR
#1	Customer Support	n = 5	\$5,163
#2	Marketplace	n = 7	\$4,322
#3	Education	n = 30	\$2,142
#4	Marketing	n = 42	\$1,586
#5	Analytics	n = 19	\$1,294
#6	Content Creation	n = 36	\$1,254
#13	AI (Artificial Intelligence)	n = 197 (Highest)	\$446

⚠ THE AI CROWDING PARADOX

197 Startups | \$446 Median MRR

AI represents nearly **20% of all startups** in the dataset, making it the most oversaturated space. Yet, its median revenue sits at a meager \$446/month.

Takeaway: Low barrier to wrapper development + intense competition = rapid commoditization and weak pricing power.

Boring utility verticals (Customer Support, Marketplaces) out-earn hyped narrative sectors.

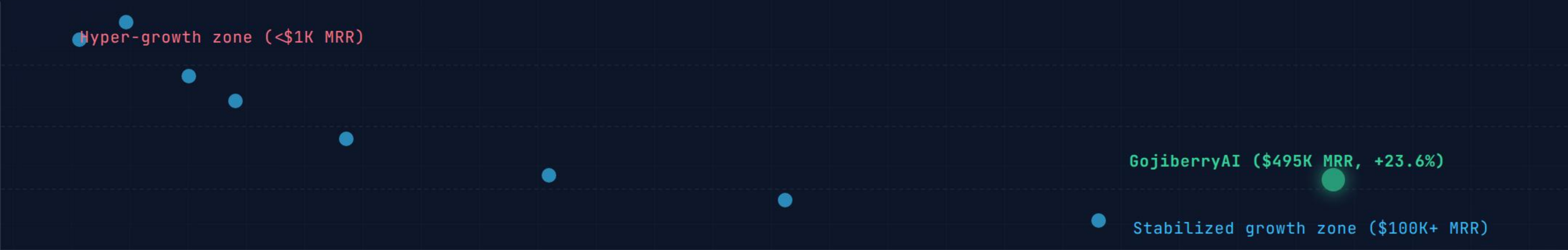
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Growth Cools as MRR Scales

Hyper-growth (>100% MoM) is almost exclusively a small/early startup phenomenon.

30-DAY GROWTH RATE % VS CURRENT MRR

Growth Rate (%) Y-Axis | MRR Scale X-Axis



Law of Small Numbers: Going from \$10 to \$100 is +900% growth, but scaling past \$50K MRR requires systematic customer retention.

Outlier Highlight: GojiberryAI maintains a high +23.6% MoM expansion despite sitting at \$495K/mo MRR scale.

Early spikes reflect baseline noise; sustainable growth rate cools predictably as scale increases. Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

Geography of Bootstrapping

The US leads both volume and startup quality; contrasting volume hubs vs revenue generators.



United States

N = 258

\$1,263

Highest median MRR & volume leader



Canada

N = 29

\$919

Strong monetization efficiency



France

N = 79

\$435

Moderate growth ecosystem



United Kingdom

N = 50

\$153

High activity, early-stage bias



India

N = 59

\$6

High startup count, near-zero median revenue



Geographic Insight: US startups benefit from native access to high-ACV markets. Indian startups exhibit massive builder enthusiasm (59 startups, #3 globally by volume), but struggle with domestic monetization and international sales distribution.

Target audience geography directly constrains pricing ceiling and willingness to pay.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

The M&A Angle: 262/1,000 Are For Sale

Over 26% of startups on TrustMRR are actively seeking an exit. Median valuation sits at 2.3x revenue.

STARTUPS LISTED "FOR SALE"

262 / 1,000

26.2% of founders are seeking immediate acquisition or asset liquidations.

MEDIAN REVENUE MULTIPLE

2.3x ARR

Asking multiples range wildly from 0x (distressed) to 327x (speculative).

Top Category Premium Multiples

1. Sales Automation **6.4x Multiple**

2. News & Magazines **6.1x Multiple**

3. Education / EdTech **4.0x Multiple**

4. Customer Support **3.8x Multiple**

5. Marketing Tech **3.7x Multiple**

High exit rates highlight founder fatigue; buyers favor mission-critical B2B sales tools.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

🔍 The Transparency Gap (Meta-Insight)

Even on a platform built for "radical openness", founders selectively obscure operational metrics.

Missing Web Traffic Data

822 / 1,000 (82.2%)



Only 178 startups disclose traffic numbers.

Missing Category or Persona

~740 / 1,000 (74.0%)



Incomplete positioning and pricing details.

⚠️ DATA BIAS WARNING

Selective Opacity in Public Reporting

Founders eager to showcase topline MRR milestones frequently conceal unit economics, customer churn rates, and visitor conversion efficiencies.

"Radical transparency is often curated marketing."

Survivorship bias & selective reporting mean true underlying startup health is even harsher.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 startups, snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026

Strategic Conclusions for MBA Audience

Three core empirical takeaways for founders, investors, and product strategists.

01

Startup Success Follows a Strict Power Law

Do not anchor plans on average market figures. Median revenue sits at \$282/mo; 50% of startups fail to build meaningful business traction. A tiny 0.5% outlier cohort captures nearly all economics.

02

B2B Business Model Fundamentals Decisively Win

B2B startups generate 5.7x higher median MRR (\$1,036 vs \$181) and 3.5x higher revenue per visitor (\$0.90 vs \$0.26) due to corporate budgets and willingness to pay for ROI.

03

Crowded Categories ≠ Profitable Opportunities

AI is the most overcrowded sector (197 startups, ~20% of market) but ranks #13 in median revenue (\$446). Focus on unsexy utility verticals (Customer Support, Marketplaces, Analytics).